

From the Top: SOUND

A five-chapter memoir on musical autonomy, structured as an acronym and paired chapter by chapter with published research

Role	Writer, researcher, and designer, solo project
Timeline	Idea and reading over several months; written and designed in a focused 2-week sprint
Format	Horizontal-scroll editorial website, five chapters, 12 cited sources
Live at	aaroncheung.me/sound

Where It Started

The idea didn't start as a memoir. It started with research on childhood music development, and reading it, I kept thinking about my own case: given everything I'd been through with music, quitting, resenting it, refusing to practice out of pure spite, the fact that I still loved music at all seemed like it shouldn't have happened. I wasn't writing about a feeling first and finding research to back it up. I was reacting to research that made my own life look statistically unlikely, and trying to write my way into understanding why.

From there, the process became iterative: I'd write about a period of my life, then look for research that explained what happened, or explained why it was unexpected. Sometimes it confirmed what I already suspected; in a few places it complicated things, and I kept those moments in rather than smoothing them over, since the friction was more honest than a clean match would have been.

Structuring the Memoir: SOUND

The acronym came after the writing, not before. Once the memoir existed, I needed a way to divide it into something readable rather than one continuous account, and SOUND, Secondhand Sound, On Someone Else's Terms, Under No One's Watch, Nothing but Ear, Da Capo, gave me five movements that also happen to spell out the subject of the piece. Each letter marks a different relationship to music: watching someone else make it, having it imposed on me, getting it back under no supervision, learning to hear instead of read, and finally choosing to start over on purpose.

The closing chapter, Da Capo, is doing double duty on purpose: it's a real musical direction, meaning return to the beginning and play it again, and it's structurally what the chapter does, the memoir ends with me a beginner again, by choice this time, picking up new instruments the same way I started with piano as a kid. The title functions both as metaphor and instruction: the final chapter returns the reader and writer to the beginning. The site's title, "From the Top," carries the same instruction: return to the beginning and begin again.

A Structural Device: The Violin Thread

One thing I built deliberately rather than let happen naturally: the violin storyline is tracked explicitly across the piece as a recurring thread, with its own labeled callouts, “Appearance 1 of 3,” “2 of 3,” “3 of 3,” noting what the thread had done and what to watch for next. Violin enters in chapter O as a secondary instrument I resented less than piano but still avoided practicing. It reappears in U once piano stopped being mandatory, now the one place my engagement was visibly changing even though nothing about its own terms had changed. It resolves in N, where violin turns out to be the instrument that revealed I had a real ear at all, the discovery that eventually let me start playing piano by ear too.

I made that thread visible in the interface itself rather than leaving it for an attentive reader to notice on their own. It's a small piece of information design sitting inside a personal essay: telling the reader explicitly that a pattern is being tracked, and where it's headed, without giving away the ending.

Designing Around a Finished Text

The visual system came entirely after the writing was locked, as its own separate design phase, and it went through four major visual iterations before landing anywhere close to what's live now. The inspiration going in was straightforward: bold magazine-style blocks of black and white with red as an accent, big lettering, high contrast.

What wasn't straightforward was translating that into something that worked on screen. Each iteration failed for a specific, identifiable reason:

- **First version:** the SOUND letters rendered huge, in red, taking up roughly three-quarters of the page, with story text layered on top, the way a print magazine spread works. It looked right in a mockup and fell apart in a browser: what reads as bold in print reads as overwhelming on a screen someone is trying to read.
- **Second version:** I kept the oversized letters but made the page parallax-scrolling, so the letters shifted out of the way as the reader scrolled. This solved the overwhelm problem and created a new one: the movement was distracting, pulling attention away from the words instead of framing them.
- **Third version:** I flattened the letters and hollowed them out, outline only, to quiet them down. This solved the distraction problem but overcorrected, the result looked like a poster advertising the essay rather than an interface for reading it.
- **Fourth pass:** within the block-based black-and-white direction that eventually stuck, I added intricate linework, fine detail layered into the bold shapes. Up close, it looked good. Zoomed out, at reading scale, it just read as clutter, and I pulled it back out.

What survived across every iteration was the instinct that bold black-and-white blocking with red accents was the right foundation. What each failed version taught me was a specific way that foundation could go wrong once it actually had to hold a few thousand words of first-person writing: too much presence, too much motion, too much self-announcement, too much detail. The final system is less a single insight than the sum of four things I ruled out. I don't have saved artifacts from the earlier versions, only memory of them, so the record above is descriptive rather than illustrated.

The Real Structural Decision: Black, Cream, and Control

The design problem that actually needed solving once the visual noise cleared was simpler: the memoir was, as written, walls of text, five chapters of first-person narrative with research sidebars, a lot of reading with little to signal where you are.

The solution came from going back to the content itself rather than adding more visual decoration. Each chapter of my life described in SOUND falls into one of two states: periods where a choice was made for me, and periods where I was making the choice myself. That's not the same axis as happy versus sad, some of the chapters where I had control were still difficult. It's specifically about who was holding the decision.

I mapped that distinction directly onto the page: chapters defined by imposed choices render as high-contrast black spreads, chapters defined by my own agency render as light, cream-colored spreads. The alternation as you scroll through the piece isn't just visual pacing, though it does that too, it's the memoir's actual thesis rendered as a structural rule you experience physically, scrolling from a dark spread into a light one at the exact moment the narrative shifts from something happening to me into something I chose.

The alternation isn't decoration. It's the argument of the piece, encoded as a rule you scroll through rather than a claim you read.

Other Systems Worth Naming

A few smaller decisions work together to reinforce the same idea, that this is a piece about music, built like one:

- The site scrolls horizontally, spread by spread, rather than the vertical infinite-scroll most web content defaults to. Reading it feels closer to turning pages in a score or a print magazine than browsing a normal page.
- None of this is built from images. The huge letters, the diagonal splits, every visual element on the page is pure typography and CSS, no canvas, no illustration, no rasterized assets. The magazine feel comes entirely from type.
- The chapter-letter rail that stays pinned beside the text as you scroll isn't static, it tracks scroll position live and inverts its own light/dark tone to match whichever entry is currently alongside it, so the control/no-control system stays synced to the reading position rather than being fixed per chapter.
- Header and footer are styled as music staff lines with actual notation dots, extending the metaphor into interface chrome rather than only content.
- Drop caps, oversized outlined section letters, and bold italic pull-quotes create a consistent editorial rhythm across all five chapters.

Adapting to Mobile: When the Metaphor Doesn't Travel

The horizontal, spread-based reading experience is central to the desktop design, but it doesn't work on a phone: side-scrolling assumes a wide viewport and a mouse or trackpad, neither of which describes a screen operated with a thumb. Rather than force the desktop metaphor into a space it doesn't fit, I rebuilt the layout for mobile as a vertical, stacked read, keeping the rest of the visual system, the SOUND letter navigation, the black and cream chapter alternation, the red accent color, the drop caps and pull-quotes, intact.

The chapter letters that anchor each desktop spread carry over as section markers in the vertical flow, and the black/cream logic still tracks control versus imposed choice exactly as it does on desktop, just as a vertical sequence of blocks instead of a horizontal one. The content, hierarchy, and thesis didn't change; the reading mechanic did, because keeping the original one would have meant a broken experience rather than a faithfully translated one.

Outcome

The finished piece is live, complete, and holds together as both a written and designed work: roughly 5,000 words across 17 spreads and five chapters. All five chapters carry the SOUND thesis through to the closing chapter: imposed practice can produce skill while draining the wonder that made you want to play in the first place, while autonomy is what lets the desire to play survive. Twelve academic sources are cited throughout, each doing real argumentative work rather than sitting as decoration; several, particularly the research on forced versus chosen motivation, directly shape the essay's central claim rather than just supporting a point already made in the text. The final result is less a webpage containing an essay and more an editorial environment where typography, interaction, and narrative structure reinforce the same idea.

Reflection

The design process took about as long as the writing did, roughly a week each, after months of the idea and the reading sitting with me before I sat down to actually build anything. The writing and design phases required roughly equal time, which surprised me going in: the writing came fast once I sat down to do it, and the visual system took the same amount of time to fail its way to something right. That felt backwards going in: writing about my own life should have been the harder part, but it wasn't. Knowing what the piece was already trying to say made writing it mostly a matter of getting out of my own way. Designing around a finished, meaningful text required its own kind of judgment, knowing when bold was working and when it had tipped into loud, and I didn't have as much intuition for that going in as I expected.

If I did this again, I'd try to shorten the distance between the magazine-mockup version and the final block system. Three of the four discarded versions were really the same lesson in different forms: big, attention-grabbing typography competes with long-form reading no matter how you dress it up. The lesson wasn't that bold typography was wrong. It was that every design decision has to answer to the content it serves.